

before Holst left to work in Greece for several months; a second incomplete performance in 1919 (only five of the seven movements were played) was the beginning of the suite's recognition as a masterpiece of orchestral imagination. Holst was uneasy at its success, however, feeling that it drew attention away from his other works, such as the choral Hymn of Jesus of 1917.

Forced by overwork to take a year's rest from teaching, in 1924 Holst completed his Choral Symphony, based on poems by John Keats. His output then slowed, although he felt that Egdon Heath, an orchestral evocation of the bleak landscape of Thomas Hardy's novel *The Return of the Native* (1878), was his finest single achievement. The onset of a duodenal ulcer eventually led to an operation that Holst's weak heart did not survive. The *Planets* has ensured, though, that his name will live on.